Out on the roads, there was indeed a crisis. The highway between Tel Aviv and Haifa, Israel's second- and third-largest cities, was a parking lot in many places. It took three-and-a-half hours for some commuters to reach Tel Aviv from Hadera, a city just thirty miles to the north. One man, trudging off a two-hour bus ride from nearby Netanya, thought back wistfully to his recent family vacation in Greece. "The flight was faster than this," he joked.

The reason for all this was a surreal one, even by local standards. Israel Railways, the state-owned train company, had scheduled a round of maintenance for the previous day, 3 September—a Saturday, the Jewish day of rest. The timing made sense: trains do not run on Saturdays, road traffic is light, and most workers have the day off. Indeed, the company often schedules work for the sabbath. "We've been doing this for years," said Keren Turner, the director-general of Katz's ministry. Just a week earlier, also on Shabbat, the rail company expanded the passenger terminal in central Tel Aviv, which sits in the middle of its main urban freeway, the Ayalon. The project required hoisting two 560-ton, 60-meter-long structures into position, in little over 24 hours—no small feat of engineering, the sort of achievement many governments would brag about. Ultra-Orthodox lawmakers, the self-proclaimed guardians of the sabbath, chose to look the other way.

They are not always so accommodating: there have been mass prayer rallies and protests, occasionally violent ones, against the opening of movie theaters, shopping malls, even a parking lot. This wasn't even Israel's first Shabbat-linked coalition crisis. Yitzhak Rabin barely survived a no-confidence motion in 1976 after Israel received its first shipment of F-15 fighter jets from the United States. The planes landed in the late afternoon, and the welcoming ceremony did not end until well after dark. More than two decades later, in 1999, the electric company needed to move a giant turbine from Tel Aviv to the port city of Ashkelon. It would have snarled weekday traffic across central Israel, because the truck carrying it could only move at a few miles per hour. So the company decided to ship it on a Saturday, which caused United Torah Judaism, one of the two ultra-Orthodox parties, to leave Ehud Barak's coalition.

Netanyahu is secular, like many of his predecessors, but the prime minister's office goes to great lengths to avoid publicly desecrating Shabbat or otherwise violating Jewish law. The ultra-Orthodox press was briefly